From 1962 for a full decade, India made a hard-headed comeback, even if ground was retrieved only partially. Domestically, India sought to overcome the shock of its defeat and resisted territorial concessions to Pakistan in Jammu and Kashmir as the price to be paid to the West for its assistance. Political instability, including succession processes, added to economic distress arising from the failure of monsoons. A number of domestic political agitations – from Tamil Nadu to Punjab – undid the message of stability achieved in the first years of independence. Not entirely inappropriately, our nation was seen to have entered a ‘dangerous decade’. The world itself was still very much bipolar but the two superpowers now had a common interest in working to check China. Significantly, India was one of the key focal points of this shared endeavour. While the China front remained relatively stable for India – not least because that country slid into the Cultural Revolution – the Pakistan one became increasingly dangerous, culminating in the 1965 conflict. The superpower condominium was very much at work in forcing on India a difficult compromise at Tashkent. Economic difficulties aggravated and American pressures mounted on the Vietnam question as India also saw a Soviet overture to Pakistan that represented its reading of the subcontinental reality. This period came to a head with two extraordinary events of realism that were cause and consequence.

The first was the Sino-US rapprochement of 1971 that was achieved with the facilitation of Pakistan and fundamentally altered the global strategic scenario. The second was a response of two directly affected parties that came in the form of an Indo-Soviet Treaty. For India, it represented a compromise between non-alignment and strategic security. The precipitating factor was, of course, the decisions of a Pakistani leadership that eventually led to a conflict with India. It is tempting to speculate whether India would have taken such a tough call in the headier days of international diplomacy. While we will never know, the fact is that its victory in the 1971 Bangladesh conflict represented a partial recovery from the reverses of 1962. More important, by breaking the equivalence with Pakistan, India ushered in a phase of greater regionalism.

This period, in fact, countered the pre-1962 tendency and should be valued for that, perhaps even more than the outcomes themselves. The willingness